Conflict of Interest Statement

Manuscript: Does Rubric-Guided Self-Refinement Improve Prompts from Small-Model Optimizers? A Scoped Negative-Result Study with Qwen3-1.7B (revised submission; Access-2026-54235, initial submission Access-2026-44920)

None of the authors (Linh Nguyen, Quang-Vinh Dang, Minh Ngoc Dinh and Thuy Nguyen) has a conflict of interest to disclose. The same statement appears in the manuscript under "Declaration of Competing Interest".